Does the folder earn its place?

A folder of instructions is meant to help an AI answer questions about a set of documents. This test checked whether it does.

No. The folder got the AI to its answers in half the steps, but its answers were marked right less often than with the documents alone.

The experiment

The same 10 questions, asked of the same AI, in three set-ups. Each set-up was asked every question 3 times.

Nothing

No documents, no folder. The AI only has the question.

No instructions

0	2.00
marked right, of 30	steps per question

Documents alone

18 documents to search. No instructions.



No instructions

30
marked right, of 30

5.03
steps per question

Documents with the folder

The same 18 documents, plus 4 instruction files read first.



map role rules examples

23 to 28
marked right, of 30

2.37
steps per question

How it was run

Each step was committed before the next one began, so nothing could be shaped to fit the result.

1. **Rule fixed**
   How the folder would be judged, written before anything else.
2. **Documents**
   ChatGPT wrote 18 documents for two made-up organisations.
3. **Questions**
   ChatGPT wrote 20, with answers. It never saw the folder.
4. **Answers checked**
   Gemini answered all 20 with no answer key. All agreed.
5. **Random draw**
   A script picked the 10 exam questions. Nobody chose.
6. **570 sessions**
   Claude answered in 19 set-ups, from one command.

7 Graded 3 times
Twice by Claude, once by Gemini, set-up hidden.

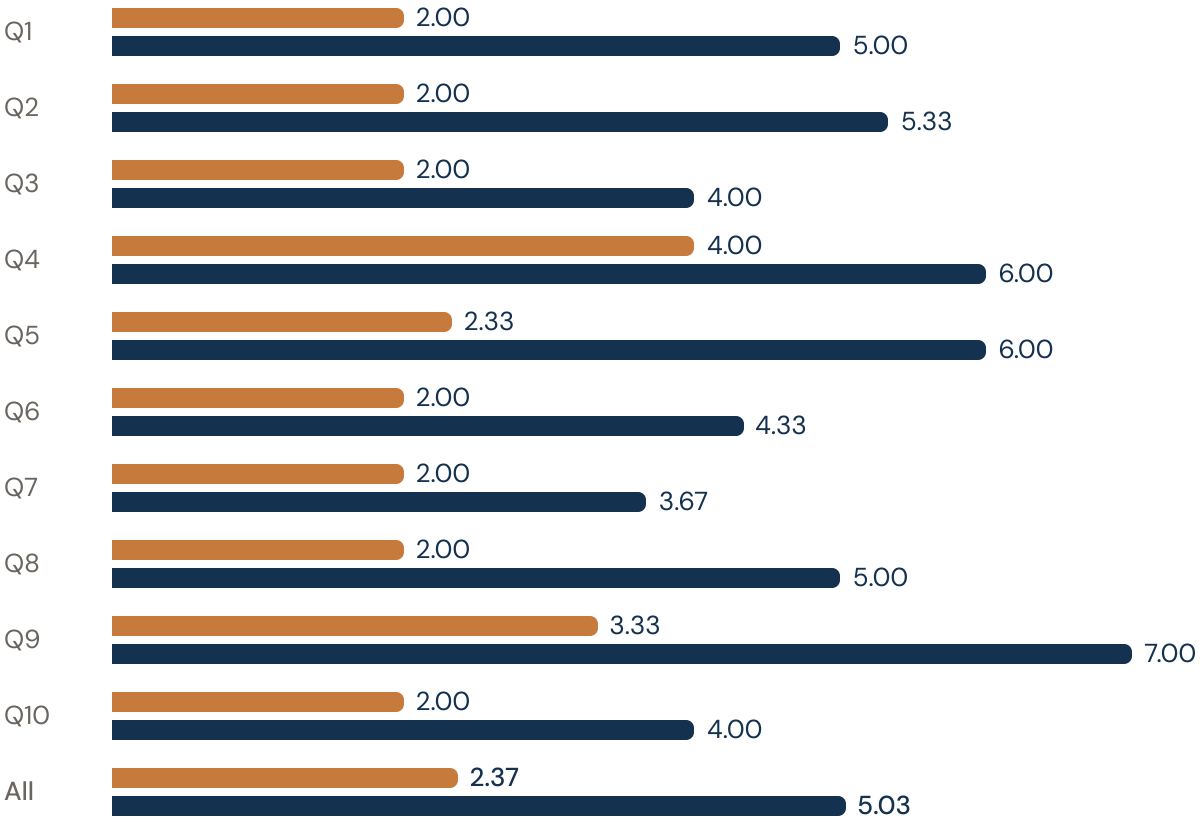
8 Results built
By script, from the raw logs. All of it is in the repo.

The results

Documents with the folder Documents alone

Steps to reach an answer

Searches and files opened, per question. Fewer with the folder on 10 of 10.



Answers marked right, of 30

Each of the three gradings.



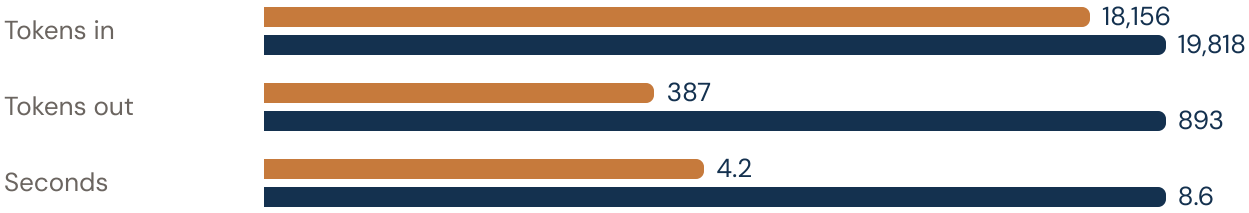
Text put in front of the AI

Characters per question. The lighter part is the folder's own files, read every time.



Cost per question

Tokens are the units an AI is billed in.



The rule, fixed before the run

The folder earns its place only if all three hold.

Steps clearly fall

Met. Fewer on 10 of 10 questions.

Right answers do not fall

Not met. 23 to 28 against 30.

Text does not rise

Not met. 9,689 against 7,191.

Why the folder lost marks

The folder tells the AI to answer what was asked and then stop. Its answers were right on the main point and less than half the length. The answer key also wanted the detail a longer answer includes, such as how far over a limit something was.

What held up

- The map does the work on steps: 2.50 with the map alone, 6.07 with nothing loaded.
- A re-run from a fresh copy gave the same result: 2.50 against 5.10.
- On 10 questions kept aside, the folder took fewer steps on all 10.

What this does not show

- One AI model, made-up documents, ten questions, one day.
- The graders could tell the two set-ups apart from the writing.
- Nobody else has run it on another machine yet.

Where to look. `START-HERE.md` is the guide. `results.md` has every figure, tie and loss.

Weekly Comp #14, The Control. Run on 12 October 2026. AI the vL Way. Less hype. More help.